

THE BAD GIRL GOSPEL SERIES

BOOK FOUR

~~Good Girl~~

~~Less~~

~~Sorry~~

~~Humble~~

~~Small~~

~~Quiet~~

~~Grateful~~

~~Enough~~

No more.

SHE BUILT
HER OWN
TABLE.

—
THEN SHE
CHOSE WHO
SAT AT IT.

FAITH
WEALTH
STRATEGY
FREEDOM

bad girl gospel

THE STORY OF NAOMI

A confession about money, hunger,
and the woman they called *heartless*.

SABINO PEREIRA

Bad Girl Gospel: The Story of Naomi

*A Confession About Money, Hunger, and the Woman
They Called Heartless*

Sabino Pereira

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Fiction Note

This is a fictional literary work. Naomi is not written as a perfect victim or a complete villain. She is a character built from contradiction, hunger, shame, ambition, fear, control, tenderness, and the difficult work of becoming honest. This book does not celebrate cruelty. It asks what happens when survival begins to look like greed, and when a woman who once had nothing decides she will never be powerless again. Some wounds make people softer. Some wounds make people strategic. Some make them hard to love before they learn how to feel safe. Naomi lives in that tension.

This is not a story about money alone. It is a story about what money comes to mean when you have known instability, humiliation, dependence, and the quiet violence of never having enough. It is also a story about the names women are given when they stop confusing sacrifice with holiness.

Author's Note

Bad Girl Gospel: The Story of Naomi began as a question: What if heartless was not who she was, but the name the world gave to a woman who refused to stay hungry in order to be called good? Naomi is a fictional character, but her contradictions are human. She wants security without becoming a machine. She wants power without becoming cruel. She wants love without becoming dependent. She wants God without pretending she does not care about money, control, or the fear of losing everything. This book is not about excusing every wound. It is about telling the truth about what wounds can become.

Some women are called soft when they are starving. Some are called selfish when they finally eat. Some are called heartless when they stop offering their bodies, time, ambition, and future as proof of goodness. Naomi stands in that accusation. A baddie is what they see. A bad girl is what they judge. A free woman is what she is trying to become.

Opening Manifesto

A Confession About Money, Hunger, and the Woman They Called Heartless

My name is Naomi.

I am not your warning, your sermon illustration, or your lesson in misplaced priorities.

You called me materialistic because I learned the price of dependence early.

You called me cold because I stopped confusing access with love.

You called me heartless because I refused to keep starving just to make other people feel comfortable.

I know what hunger does.

I know what it does to a house.

To a mother.

To a girl listening through thin walls.

To a body that learns too early that money is not just money.

Money is food.

Money is rent.

Money is silence.

Money is a locked door.

Money is the difference between leaving and staying because you have no choice.

So yes, I like money.

Not because I worship it.

Because I remember what it was like to need it and not have it.

Because I remember the humiliation of asking.

Because I remember the way people speak to you when they know you cannot afford to say no.

I did not become ambitious by accident.

I became ambitious because fear is expensive.

Because instability leaves a taste in your mouth that never fully goes away.

Because once you have seen what powerlessness does to a woman, you do not romanticize dependence again.

People like to tell my story in ugly, easy words.

Gold digger.

User.

Ice queen.

Too much.

Never satisfied.

The kind of woman who would choose a promotion over a person.

The kind of woman who would rather build an empire than a family.

The kind of woman who does not know how to love unless love arrives itemized, insured, and impossible to weaponize.

Some of those accusations contain fragments of truth.

That is what makes them dangerous.

I have used money as armor.

I have used success as proof that no one can ever humiliate me again.

I have measured people by whether they felt safe or expensive or useful.

I have left before love could become leverage.
I have stayed in rooms that made me feel powerful long after
they stopped making me feel human.

That does not make me innocent.
It makes me honest.

There were years when I trusted numbers more than people.
Years when a full account felt holier than a full heart.
Years when I would rather be admired than held, because
admiration asks less of you than intimacy.

And yes, there were times when I looked at motherhood and felt
not wonder, but terror.

Not because I hate children.
Because I know what it means to build a life inside lack.
Because I know what it costs a woman to keep giving when
nobody asks what she has left.
Because I have seen too many women disappear into sacrifice
and get praised for the vanishing.

They call that holiness.

I do not.

They called her heartless because she stopped letting hunger
make her holy.

That is the sentence they will not forgive in me.

Not that I wanted more.
That I wanted more and refused to apologize for the wanting.
Not that I feared poverty.
That I feared it enough to build a life no one could easily control.

Not that I questioned love.

That I questioned any love that arrived asking me to be smaller,
softer, poorer, or more grateful than free.

Do not worship me.

Do not reduce me either.

I know ambition can turn a woman sharp.

I know fear can dress itself up as standards.

I know self-protection can become a religion if you kneel to it
long enough.

I know there are people I hurt while trying not to be hurt first.

I carry that too.

I still talk to God.

In elevators.

In airport bathrooms.

In the dark after closing deals that should have felt better than
they did.

In expensive rooms where everything is quiet except my own
mind.

I do not come to Him pretending I am simple.

I come as a woman who has made security into a sacrament.

A woman who has turned spreadsheets into psalms.

A woman who still does not know the full difference between
wisdom and fear.

A woman who wants to be safe so badly she sometimes forgets
how to be soft.

If that makes you uncomfortable, take it to God.

I already did.

I do not want to be the good woman in your story.
I want to be the honest one in mine.

If I hurt you, I will not call it empowerment.
If you tried to control me, I will not call it love.
If money saved me, I will not lie and say it meant nothing.
If money hardened me, I will not lie about that either.

I am not proud of every version of myself that survival created.
But I will not insult her for learning how to eat.

A baddie is what you see.
A bad girl is what you judge.
A heartless woman is what you call me when my hunger stops
serving you.

My name is Naomi.

And this is my gospel.

Chapter 1

The Rumor

No one really knew Naomi. But everyone had a story about her. She is cold. She only cares about money. She is ambitious in a masculine way. She uses men and calls it discernment. She would choose a contract over a child. She would choose security over softness every time. She is the kind of woman who makes love feel like an invoice. They said it in office kitchens and private group chats, in bridal showers and conference corridors, in church foyers and restaurants with low lighting and expensive glassware.

Men talked about Naomi like a warning. Women talked about her like a flaw in the culture. Church people talked about her like a prayer request with good posture. She is successful, but something is wrong with her. She is polished, but there is no warmth. She is beautiful, but difficult. She is smart, but too sharp. She has standards, but no softness. She has money, but no peace. No one told the same story twice. Details changed. Timelines shifted. Facts got dressed up and sent back out. But one thing remained the same:

the way they said her name like a correction, like a caution, like a woman who had once been tender and made the mistake of learning numbers. By the time Naomi entered a room, the room had usually introduced her already. If she arrived alone, they called it arrogance. If she arrived with a man, they calculated his watch before they looked at her face. If she paid the bill, they called it a performance. If he paid the bill, they called it strategy. If she spoke clearly, she was aggressive. If she stayed quiet, she was judging everyone. The accusation never depended on what she did. Only the wording changed.

At dinners, people watched Naomi the way some people watch markets, hoping for a collapse they can later call inevitable. She wore silence well. That bothered people. Her clothes were always precise. Not loud. Not apologetic either. She looked like a woman who had made choices on purpose, and the world has never been fully comfortable with women who look deliberate. Especially if they are not apologizing for what the deliberateness bought them.

The men noticed first. They always did. Not because they understood her, but because they assumed a woman with that face and that salary had to be one of two things: a fantasy or a threat. Sometimes both.

At bars, after conferences, over second drinks and fake honesty, men told stories about Naomi as if surviving her had made them wiser. Bro, she is not built for normal love. She interviews you over dinner. She makes you feel like you are applying for funding. She asks questions like she is trying to buy the company. She does not want a partner. She wants leverage. They laughed when they said it. Men always laugh hardest when rejection has bruised their ego in a place they cannot explain.

They never mentioned how quickly they had admired her before they resented her. They never mentioned how much they liked her ambition when it was still flattering them. They never mentioned how often they mistook access for intimacy and generosity for ownership. A reservation became a claim. A weekend became a forecast. A gift became a pressure point. Then Naomi would say no, or not yet, or I will pay my half, or I am not moving into a house I cannot leave on my own salary, and suddenly the story changed.

She is damaged. She does not know how to receive. She wants a provider, but she does not know how to submit. She wants the benefits of a man without the responsibilities of a woman. That last sentence traveled well. It sounded good in male mouths. It sounded even better in religious ones. The women were more careful with

their cruelty. They smiled first.

They complimented her coat, her shoes, her discipline, her work ethic, her ability to “carry herself.” Then they began the real inventory. Who was she dating? Was he rich? Was he older? Why had she not married yet? Why did she never seem impressed? Why did she always look like she could leave in the middle of the meal and not regret the bill, the man, or the conversation? Women who had built their lives around endurance did not always know what to do with a woman who had built hers around escape. Some envied her. Some distrusted her. Some studied her as if she were a moral failure in excellent tailoring.

She is what happens when women get too much freedom. She thinks money can protect her from loneliness. She acts like motherhood is beneath her. She is one of those women who wants everything and calls it healing. She has made her career into a religion. Sometimes the women were wrong. Sometimes they were close enough to the truth to leave fingerprints. Because Naomi had, in fact, made work into a sanctuary on certain days. She had, in fact, trusted numbers more than people. She had, in fact, looked at marriage proposals hidden inside soft language and heard handcuffs instead of romance.

But none of them asked why. That was the thing about rumor. It likes outcomes. It hates origins. No one asked where her fear came from. No one asked what hunger had taught her. No one asked why a woman might hear “I’ll take care of you” and feel her whole nervous system reach for the nearest exit. The church people had their own version. They never said gold digger first.

They used words that had been washed and ironed for Sunday. Stronghold. Control. Idolatry. Fear. Unhealed ambition. Difficulty receiving feminine grace. They said Naomi had a beautiful mind, but. They said Naomi was clearly gifted, but. They said Naomi had leadership, but. There was always a but. She needs to soften. She

needs to trust God more than money. She needs to stop striving. She needs to stop trying to be the man in every room. She needs to heal whatever made her so afraid of motherhood. That one was usually said more quietly.

Not because it was kinder. Because it landed harder. The church women watched Naomi with the concentration of people trying to solve a theological problem in real time. How does a woman love God and still refuse dependence? How does a woman pray and still negotiate contracts like war? How does a woman quote Scripture and still say she does not want children? How does a woman succeed without making sacrifice her whole personality? To them, Naomi was not just a person. She was a disruption.

A woman who did not fit cleanly into the old equations: softness equals holiness, marriage equals maturity, motherhood equals fulfillment, money equals compromise, ambition equals danger unless a man is carrying it. Naomi violated too many formulas at once. So they named her. Heartless. Worldly. Controlling. Unsubmissive. Brilliant but barren. A woman who had mistaken survival for wisdom and achievement for intimacy.

Online, the rumor got meaner. People are always bolder when the person they are describing has become a silhouette. Under interviews, photographs, event clips, and conference panels, strangers turned Naomi into a theory. She looks exhausting. You can tell she would never love a man unless he came with assets. She is the type to freeze her eggs and call it empowerment. Probably too busy building her empire to build a family. Women like this always end up alone. Money talks until the house gets quiet.

The comments came from strangers, wives, bored men, fake prophets, disappointed romantics, women hiding resentment under concern, and men who feared any woman who asked where the money went before she asked where the relationship was going. Naomi rarely answered. Silence made people more inventive. If she

defended herself, she was pressed. If she ignored them, she was arrogant. If she smiled, she was smug. If she looked tired, they called it karma. She had learned early that once people want a woman to represent a lesson, they stop needing facts.

All they need is a face. Naomi had the right face for projection. Controlled. Unreadable. Expensive enough to offend. Beautiful enough to invite theories. Self-contained enough to make people wonder what exactly she had survived to become this exact. At one fundraiser, a woman in a silk dress and practiced kindness leaned toward another and whispered, not quietly enough, That is Naomi. The one who chose money over everything.

The other woman asked, over what? The first woman did not hesitate. Over love. Over children. Over softness. Over the kind of life that makes a woman human. Naomi heard it. Of course she did.

People often mistake composure for deafness. She turned slightly, accepted a glass of sparkling water from a server, and thanked him with the calm of someone who had no intention of collapsing for the comfort of witnesses. But inside, something old moved. Not shame. Not exactly. Recognition.

Because the rumor was cruel. But it was not random. It had been built from visible choices and invisible history. It had taken the sharp outline of her life and filled in the missing parts with contempt. No one asked what little girls learn when the rent is late. No one asked what daughters notice when a mother has to beg. No one asked what happens to a child who grows up understanding that every soft thing in the house depends on whether someone else feels generous that month. No one asked where the hunger came from. That was the oldest insult of all.

People looked at Naomi's appetite and called it greed. They looked at her caution and called it cruelty. They looked at her standards and called them punishment. They looked at her refusal

and called it pride. They never looked for the famine underneath. By the end of the night, Naomi was no longer just a woman in a black dress with a measured voice and a hand steady enough to hold a glass without betraying irritation.

She had become content. A symbol. A warning for daughters. A complaint in a husband's mouth. A case study in a pastor's private theology. A villain in the romantic imagination of people who still believed a good woman should prove her heart by risking ruin. No one really knew Naomi. They only knew the version of her that made their own lives easier to defend.

If she was heartless, then they did not have to ask why women grow hard. If she was selfish, then they did not have to ask how much unpaid sacrifice they still expected from women. If she chose money over love, then they did not have to ask what kind of love had so often arrived carrying control in its pocket. If she did not want motherhood, then they did not have to ask what sort of world keeps asking women to birth hope into systems that have never kept them safe. The rumor said Naomi loved money more than people. The truth was simpler and uglier.

Naomi had learned too early that when hunger enters a house, love is often the first thing to change its tone. And before anyone knew her story, they had already named her appetite.

Chapter 2

The House That Counted Everything

The House That Counted Everything

Before Naomi loved money, she feared what happened when there was none. The house she grew up in did not just count money. It counted everything. Bread. Milk.

Light. Bus fare. Laundry. Patience. Phone calls.

Silence. Even kindness seemed to arrive measured. Nothing in that house felt abundant. Not food. Not sleep.

Not tenderness. Not certainty. There was always some version of not enough. Not enough money for the month. Not enough food to stop everyone from noticing the portions.

Not enough peace to keep voices level once evening came. Naomi learned numbers before she learned safety. She learned the shape of coins in a tired hand. The sound of cupboards closing too hard. The meaning of envelopes left unopened on tables

as if paper itself could bite. Her mother was always tired. Not poetic tired. Not the glamorous kind people perform online. Bone tired.

Rent tired. Breadwinner tired. Prayer tired. The kind of tired that lives in the shoulders and changes the temperature of a room.

Her mother moved through the house like someone always calculating. Can this stretch? Can that wait? Can we water this down?

Can we make it to Friday? Sometimes she sat at the kitchen table with receipts, a cracked mug of tea, and the face of a woman trying to

solve

a life with subtraction. Naomi watched from the doorway. Her mother's mouth moving softly over numbers. Rent. Light.

Food. School. Transport. Church. Debt.

Always debt. Debt in drawers. Debt in tone. Debt in the air. Debt made the house feel smaller than it was.

There was a man too, but his presence did not mean safety. Sometimes he was there physically and absent in every other way. Sometimes he was gone before sunrise

and late again after dark, bringing home fatigue, excuses, half-promises, and sometimes money that never seemed to stay long.

Sometimes he worked. Sometimes he drifted. Sometimes he talked big about what was coming. Sometimes he disappeared inside his own pride when the bills got louder than him.

Naomi learned early that a man in the house and provision in the house were not the same thing. That was one of the first disillusionments. Love and safety were not twins.

Presence and provision were not twins. A family and a shelter were not twins either. Through the walls, she learned even more. Children hear everything.

Even when adults whisper. Even when doors close. Even when people think they are protecting innocence by lowering their voices. Naomi lay in bed and listened.

To the scrape of a chair. To her mother's voice turned thin with restraint. To a man's reply sharpened by defensiveness. To the pauses that felt more dangerous than shouting.

You said this month would be different. I'm trying. Trying is not paying it. Do you think I don't know that? Keep your voice down.

Naomi is sleeping. She was never sleeping. She was counting. Counting seconds between words. Counting the rise in her mother's voice.

Counting the silence after accusation. Counting how long it took for money to turn love into something colder. That was the lesson the walls taught her:

love changes tone when money disappears. Not always because people stop loving. Sometimes because fear enters first and rearranges everybody's language. A tired mother sounds harsher when she is scared.

A fragile man sounds crueler when he is ashamed. A child learns to go quiet when she senses that one more need could tip the room into violence, or tears,

or prayer. Naomi became that quiet child. Not sweet quiet. Strategic quiet. She learned which questions cost too much.

Can I have seconds? Not tonight. Can we buy this? Maybe next month. Why is Mum crying?

She's just tired. Why is Dad angry? He's under pressure. Pressure became the family religion. Everyone bowed to it.

No one named it fully. The house also counted favours. This may have been the cruelest currency of all. Nothing arrived without memory. If a relative helped,

the help came back later as a story. As leverage. As humiliation in nicer clothes. Remember who paid when you needed us. Remember who bought Naomi's school things.

Remember who kept food in this house. Naomi heard her name inside adult gratitude and understood what no child should understand: need can make you feel expensive. Need can make your existence

feel like a debt someone else is carrying with visible resentment. Her mother hated begging. Naomi could tell. Not because she said the word often.

Because of what happened to her face when she had to ask for anything. Money. Time. Transport.

Mercy. There is a humiliation children can smell before they can explain it. Naomi smelled it on borrowed cash, on delayed rent,

on church kindness, on family generosity that was never fully free. She watched her mother say thank you with a straight back and wounded eyes. She watched her receive help

the way some people receive insult: carefully, politely, already bleeding. Something in Naomi hardened there.

Not all at once. Not enough for anyone to notice. Just a seed. I will never beg like this. She did not say it aloud.

Children rarely announce their deepest vows. They make them privately. In bed. In silence. While staring at ceilings

that know too much. The house counted food too. That part stayed in the body. The extra slice. The smaller plate.

The watered soup. There's enough if we share, spoken with hope and resentment mixed so tightly they became one flavour. Naomi learned to read her mother's serving spoon like weather.

A generous scoop meant maybe wages came in. A careful scoop meant hold your questions. A cheerful tone meant do not ruin this. Children in easier homes remember songs, birthdays,

cartoons. Naomi remembered portions. How much butter was left. How many eggs could still be used. Whether the cereal was being stretched.

Whether the electricity was low enough to make people move differently through the rooms. Even light was counted. Turn that off.

Don't waste water.

Open the window. Use less. Need less. Take less. The house trained her in reduction.

Reduce appetite. Reduce noise. Reduce requests. Reduce the evidence that you, too, cost money.

What no one saw was what this did to her idea of love. Love, in that house, was real. But it was tired. It came carrying calculators.

It came interrupted. It came with sighs. It came with conditions nobody wanted to admit were conditions. Not because her mother did not love her. She did.

Not because the adults were monsters. Most were not. But scarcity changes the texture of affection. It makes tenderness feel expensive. It makes patience feel luxurious.

It makes care arrive late, frayed, already carrying guilt. Naomi saw what happened to women in that economy.

How they stretched. How they waited. How they swallowed tone. How they made miracles out of leftovers and still got blamed for the emptiness.

She saw what happened to men too. How some disappeared into pride. How some hid inside anger. How some called absence provision because naming failure would have crushed them.

But it was the women she studied hardest. Her mother at the table. Her mother at the sink. Her mother at the door speaking softly to someone

she needed something from. That image never left her. A woman needing. A woman asking. A woman forced to turn dignity

into diplomacy. Naomi hated it with a child's absolute hatred. Not her mother. The position. The dependence.

The waiting. The way the whole house could be ruled by money that never fully belonged to them. That was when money stopped being just currency. It became weather.

Permission. Volume control. Breathing room. Power. The first theology Naomi learned

was not about grace. It was this: the person who pays sets the tone. Years later, people would say

she was obsessed with money. They would say she made everything transactional. That she could not relax. That she asked too many questions about costs,

terms, plans, exits. What they would not know is that Naomi had lived inside a house where nobody asked enough.

A house where love was sincere but never safe. A house where dependence sat at the table like an extra relative. A house where one unpaid bill

could change everyone's voice. That house did not make her heartless. It made her observant. Then cautious. Then determined.

Then dangerous to anyone who thought softness should come without security. By the time she was old enough to understand the word future, Naomi had already attached a vow to it.

Never this. Never the table where grown women cry over arithmetic. Never the borrowed mercy. Never the tightened jaw before asking for help. Never the child in the next room

pretending to sleep while love and lack fight through the walls. Before Naomi loved money, she feared what happened

when there was none. That fear did not leave her. It grew up with her. It learned how to dress. How to study.

How to negotiate. How to smile politely and still read a contract like a survival manual. But before it became ambition, before it

became standards,

before it became the rumor people would later call cold, it was just this: a little girl in a house that counted everything,

learning that security was never a feeling. It was always a number someone else could withhold.

Chapter 3

Good Women Stay Hungry

Good Women Stay Hungry

Naomi learned early that good women were often just hungry women praised for not complaining. The neighbourhood had a very specific idea of feminine virtue. A good woman did not ask for too much. A good woman knew how to stretch a meal,

a paycheck, a marriage, a smile. A good woman did not embarrass a man with her needs.

A good woman did not make her exhaustion other people's problem. Good women stayed. That was the first rule. They stayed in kitchens

after everyone else had eaten. They stayed in marriages after tenderness had gone sour. They stayed in churches that called their suffering holiness.

They stayed in houses where the money was short and the gratitude was expected to be long. Naomi watched them closely. Aunties.

Mothers. Church women. Neighbours with tired eyes and disciplined voices. Women who knew how to serve tea while swallowing resentment.

Women who apologized before asking for help. Women who could carry three bags, two children, one silent disappointment, and a casserole

without ever calling themselves burdened. Everyone called them good. That was what Naomi noticed. Not just that they suffered. That they were praised for it.

People admired their endurance as if endurance were the highest form of womanhood. She is such a good wife. She never talks back. She holds that family together.

She does so much with so little. She is always there for everyone. She has such a servant's heart. She is tired, but she never complains. She has been through so much,

but look how gracious she is. Grace, Naomi noticed, often meant silence with lipstick on. A servant's heart, in those circles,

often meant a woman too trained to call neglect by its name. The good women ate last. Sometimes literally. At family gatherings, Naomi saw it happen again and again.

The men sat. The children reached. The guests were served. The plates moved. The noise rose.

And the women hovered. Refilling cups. Warming food. Checking who still needed what. Asking if everyone had enough

before asking themselves if they were hungry. By the time they sat down, the rice was colder. The meat was smaller. The room was already finished

with needing them for the visible parts. Naomi noticed how casually this was accepted. She also noticed how often these women laughed while disappearing. That was another feminine skill

the community admired: make vanishing look natural. A good woman forgave quickly too. Not because healing was easy. Because everyone expected speed.

He is trying. Marriage is hard. Men have pressure too. Do not let the enemy use your offence. Pray for him.

Cover him. Be wise. Be patient. Be a helpmeet, not a headache.

Naomi heard these phrases in living rooms, after church, through half-open doors, between women who should have known better

and women who had forgotten they deserved better. Forgiveness, in those spaces, was often required long before repair. A man could fail,

drift, shout, withdraw, betray, or simply become careless

in the slow, ordinary ways that ruin women quietly, and somehow the moral pressure still landed on the woman first. Do not harden your heart. Do not become bitter.

Do not punish him forever. Think of the children. Think of your vows. Think of your witness. Naomi listened

and thought something she did not yet have the language to say cleanly: Why is goodness always measured by how much of herself a woman can lose

without making it visible? The women around her turned lack into virtue. Not because lack was beautiful. Because naming it would have threatened the whole system. If there was no money, they called it a test.

If there was no rest, they called it purpose. If there was no help, they called it strength. If there was no tenderness, they called it maturity. If there was no room for their own becoming, they called it sacrifice.

Sacrifice was the word that made everything sound cleaner than it felt. Naomi heard it everywhere. A mother sacrifices.

A wife sacrifices. A woman of God sacrifices. A real woman knows how to pour out. A woman's glory is in giving. A woman's reward is in service.

A woman's crown is in what she carries. No one mentioned what happened when she carried too much. No one asked what she had become beneath the applause.

No one seemed especially interested in whether these women were loved well. Only whether they were useful without complaint.

That distinction marked Naomi early. She saw women being congratulated for surviving conditions that would have been called failure if a man had to endure them for long.

A woman stretches. A man provides. A woman forgives. A man learns. A woman waits.

A man decides. A woman supports. A man leads. And if the whole arrangement left her smaller, thinner,

quieter, more tired, more prayerful, less visible, people called her virtuous.

Naomi did not hate these women. That is important. She pitied some. Admired some. Feared becoming almost all of them.

Because many of them were not foolish. They were intelligent. Funny. Observant. Capable.

Some had once been bright in ways the community no longer remembered to mention. A woman who used to sing before children made her speak mostly in schedules. A woman who had wanted to study

before bills and marriage turned her talent into something practical and then invisible. A woman who prayed with real power but spent most of her life

begging God to make disappointment feel holy. Naomi watched women become mothers before they ever became themselves. That stayed with her. It stayed in the way

young women were discussed. Not, What kind of life does she want? Not, What is she good at?

Not, Who is she when no one is asking her to serve? The real questions were different. Will she make a good wife? Is she humble?

Can she submit? Is she fertile? Is she nurturing? Can she build a home? Can she carry a man

without making him feel carried? Girlhood, in those spaces, often felt like rehearsal for disappearance. First daughter. Then helper.

Then wife. Then mother. Then everyone's emergency contact. Then eventually, if she was lucky,

a woman whose children might thank her for the shape her vanishing took. Naomi saw this and felt two things at once. Grief. Rebellion.

Because there was love in these women. Real love. Meals cooked through fatigue. Hair braided with tenderness. Prayers whispered over sleeping children.

Bills stretched with impossible intelligence. Bodies kept moving on almost no rest. Faith held together with safety pins and sheer obedience. Naomi was not blind to that beauty.

But she was also not blind to the theft. How often the same world that praised these women also consumed them. How often good woman

meant woman whose labour felt natural because it was unpaid, unending, and dressed in Scripture. How often selfless

meant self-erased. How often strong meant unsupported. How often patient meant trapped.

How often humble meant underdeveloped. How often family woman meant a woman with no uninterrupted life of her own. The church added polish to the arrangement.

Church language was skilled at making female exhaustion sound sacred. Pour out. Die to self. Be available to God.

Men got calling. Women got burden. Men got room to fail. Women got reminders to be gracious. Men got sermons about leadership.

Women got conferences about how to keep their homes soft while carrying the emotional weight of everyone inside them. Naomi sat in pews and listened to women testify about staying.

Staying when they were lonely. Staying when money was tight. Staying when they were overlooked. Staying when their dreams had to be postponed for a decade

that became two. Staying when their bodies were tired and their names had become relational titles. Wife. Mother.

Sister. Helper. Mummy. Mama. Auntie.

She noticed how rarely the testimonies ended with becoming. They ended with enduring. And everyone applauded. Naomi would clap too.

She was still young. Still learning how communities teach desire what is respectable. But inside, something resisted. Not God.

Not love. Not family. The script. The one where a woman became holy by disappearing well.

The one where goodness meant accepting little and calling it enough. The one where service always moved downward from women, while praise moved upward

toward the institutions and men that benefited. The one where a woman's appetite had to be starved before anyone trusted her character.

Naomi began to understand that hunger was not always about food. There was hunger for rest. For choice. For privacy.

For an unmonitored life. For money not tied to male moods. For sexuality not governed by shame. For holiness not measured by female disappearance. For selfhood before service.

The women around her carried all of that hunger under impeccable manners. And because they carried it without naming it loudly, they were called good.

Naomi learned from them. But not in the way the community intended. She did not learn how to disappear better. She learned what disappearing costs. She learned that starvation can become tradition

if enough people keep blessing it. She learned that some forms of femininity are elegant self-abandonment with a church outfit on. She learned that the world

does not always hate women by attacking them directly. Sometimes it loves them into smaller shapes. Sometimes it praises them

until they no longer know the difference between generosity and erasure. Sometimes it crowns them for surviving on crumbs and then calls their restraint

character. That was what Naomi rejected. Not just poverty. Not just instability. An entire definition of female goodness.

A goodness that required hunger. A goodness that distrusted appetite. A goodness that praised women for making themselves lighter, quieter,

cheaper, easier to carry for everyone except themselves. Naomi did not yet have the full language for this refusal. She only knew what she did not want.

She did not want to eat last forever. She did not want to forgive on command. She did not want to become one more woman whose exhaustion was mistaken for virtue. She did not want to be loved

only in proportion to how little she asked for. She did not want motherhood, if it ever came, to be the first time the world permitted her a shape.

She wanted to be a person before she became anyone's offering. That desire would later be called pride. Selfishness.

Ambition. Coldness. Rebellion. A worldly spirit. A hard heart.

But at the beginning it was simply this: a girl watching good women go hungry, and deciding that whatever goodness was,

it should not require a woman to disappear to prove she had it.

Chapter 4

The First Time Money Answered

The First Time Money Answered

The first time money answered, Naomi mistook the sound for peace. It did not look like much. No lottery. No miracle cheque.

No rich relative arriving with apologies and back pay for childhood. Just a notice on a board outside her school: Scholarship opportunity. Essay required. Limited places. She almost walked past it.

By then, Naomi had learned to distrust anything that sounded like help. Help had strings. Help had stories. Help had receipts.

But this was different. No one's face attached. No relative to owe. No church to impress. No man to thank.

Just a line of text and the quiet thought: What if this is a way to move money without moving dignity? The essay topic was broad and predictable.

Hope. Future. Community. Responsibility. Naomi rolled her eyes.

Hope had never paid a bill. Still, she took the leaflet. At home, the house was in its usual state of controlled lack. A bill on the table.

Her mother's shoulders curved over the sink. Her father half-present, half-elsewhere, a man in conversation with his own disappointments. Naomi went to her room

and wrote. Not about hope. Not really. She wrote about houses that counted everything.

About women who ate last. About hunger given new names to make it bearable. About the quiet violence of being raised to be grateful for not enough.

She translated it into something acceptable for a scholarship committee. But the edge was there. She handed it in with no ceremony. A teacher nodded.

“We’ll see.

There are many applicants. Don’t get your hopes up.” Naomi did not. Her hope was busy elsewhere surviving.

Weeks passed. The house stayed small. The bills stayed loud. Her mother stayed tired. Her father stayed inconsistent.

Then one afternoon, a name echoed over a crackling speaker in the school hallway. Naomi. Please come to the office. She went,

heart steady. The principal smiled the way adults smile when they feel generous by association.

“Congratulations, Naomi.

You’ve been awarded the scholarship.” She blinked. He explained. It covered part of her fees. Came with a stipend.

Not huge. But something. Something that would be paid to her. Not to her parents.

Not to a church. Not to a landlord. To her. They handed her a letter and a form.

She signed with a hand that did not shake until she walked out of the office. Outside, the hallway buzzed. Life carried on.

No choir sang. Naomi stood there, letter in hand, and felt the world tilt by a fraction. Not joy. Not yet.

More like a door unlocking. At home, she did the math. If she saved most, she could help.

If she kept some, she could breathe. If she was careful, she could do both. The first payment came in cash,

in a small, unremarkable envelope. The administrator slid it across the desk.

“This is yours, Naomi.

Use it wisely.” Yours. Not hers as in the house. Hers as in the girl who had spent a childhood

watching other people count. She walked home with the envelope hidden inside her bag. Every step felt like conspiracy. At the corner shop, she paused. Inside:

shelves she knew too well, foods she had measured with her eyes for years, items her mother walked past with a sigh disguised as practicality. Naomi went in.

She did not fill a basket. She was not reckless yet. She chose with the precision of someone who understood exactly how much her money

could and could not do. Bread. Milk. Eggs. A small cut of meat

that was not the cheapest but still within reason. And then, almost as an act of rebellion, a packet of biscuits

her mother always said were too expensive for their kind of month. At the till, she counted. Twice. Then placed the money on the counter.

The cashier rang it up without comment. No lecture. No sigh. No reminder of what else

could have been done with the same amount. The receipt was short. Paid in full. Naomi folded it with care. At home, her mother’s back was turned to the door.

Naomi set the bags on the counter. Her mother turned, ready to ask where that came from, ready to fight the humiliation of another debt.

Before she could speak, Naomi held up the receipt.

“I paid.”

Her mother stared.

“With what?”

Naomi passed her the letter. Scholarship. Stipend. Explanation. Her mother read,

lips moving silently, eyes widening, brow furrowing at the parts that sounded too good to be true.

“You didn’t have to,”

“I wanted to,” Naomi said.

There was more inside that sentence. I wanted to know what it feels like to bring money in without begging. Her mother’s face did something strange. Pride.

Relief. Fear. Loss. Pride, because her daughter had done something remarkable.

Relief, because for tonight, at least, there was enough. Fear, because she knew what the world does

to women who think they can rely on themselves. Loss, because this moment confirmed what she had suspected: Naomi would not stay small.

They cooked. The house smelled different. Not rich. Not decadent. Just less strained.

The portions were a little larger. The tension a little softer. The conversation a little less sharp. Her father came home, eyes cloudy

with the day's failures.

He saw the food and sat a little straighter.

"Good day?" he asked.

Naomi's mother answered for them.

"Naomi got a scholarship."

He looked at his daughter for a long moment. His face held too many things for Naomi to comfortably study. Pride,

quickly dressed as humour.

"So now you're the rich one?"

Naomi shrugged.

"Not rich.

Just paid." They laughed. It bordered on something else. On relief. On discomfort.

On the shift of an old hierarchy. Later that night, after dishes, small talk, and the shallow peace of a day without new crises,

Naomi lay in bed and replayed the day. The envelope. The shop. The look on her mother's face when she said, I paid.

The way the house had exhaled without anyone having to raise their voice to make it happen. She realized something, and it unsettled her.

The house sounded different when money came in through her hands. Not because it was better money. Because it carried no humiliation. No one had to rehearse gratitude

for a specific person. No one had to take calls they did not want to take. No one had to listen to lectures about being wise with what they were given.

The only conversation was logistics. What shall we cook? How shall we stretch this? Can we keep some for tomorrow? It was almost peace.

And Naomi, who had grown up measuring the volume of fear in a room by how people talked around bills, heard the difference. The first time money answered,

she heard a new sound. Not love. Not faith. Not joy. Control.

Dangerous, quiet control. Control over what was bought. Control over when it was bought. Control over how long the calm would last.

She liked it. That scared her. Not enough to stop. Just enough to make a decision. If this small amount could do this,

what could more do? Not for outfits. Not for attention. Not for status. For exits.

For options. For silence that did not depend on male moods. For nights without whispered arguments. For days when her mother

could sit without a calculator and feel like the world was not about to collapse because a letter came in the post. Soon after, another opportunity came.

Someone in the neighbourhood needed tutoring for their daughter. Maths. English. Nothing complicated.

They could not pay much, they said. Naomi smiled. Anything is something. She took it.

She sat at kitchen tables with younger girls whose mothers hovered in doorways, relieved to outsource one small responsibility.

She explained fractions. Grammar. Exam techniques. Quietly building a new equation for herself. Time plus competence

equals money. Not charity. Not favour. Not owed. Earned.

Each small payment went into an envelope in her drawer. She did not flaunt it. She did not announce it to the house unless it became food.

Sometimes it did. Sometimes it stayed hidden. When bills came now, Naomi felt the old panic rise and then watched as a newer feeling

stepped forward. What if I can do something? One evening, another light notice arrived. Another threat in red. Her mother's shoulders began their familiar curve.

"Leave it," Naomi said.

"I'll handle this one."

Her mother frowned.

"How?"

Naomi fetched the envelope from her drawer. Coins. Notes. The quiet accumulation of afternoons spent teaching.

She poured it out on the table. For a moment, everybody just looked. This time, Naomi insisted on being the one to walk to the payment office. Her mother tried to argue.

"It's not your job."

Naomi shook her head.

"It's my house too."

At the kiosk, she placed the money on the counter. The clerk processed it, stamped a receipt, and slid it back. Paid.

Just a word. Small print. Routine for them. It felt like revolution for her. Walking back, Naomi noticed how her body felt.

Lighter in some places. Heavier in others. Light, because she had done what had always felt like magic belonging only to adults.

Heavy, because she understood the temptation ahead. If money could do this, what else could it do? What else could she avoid,

escape, reject, rewrite if she had enough? Inside, her mother hugged her

longer than usual.

“Thank you.”

Naomi stiffened for a second. She hated that phrase in certain tones. But this time, it did not feel like debt. It felt like acknowledgement.

Still, while her mother’s chin rested on her shoulder, Naomi made a quiet correction in her mind. This is the last time I will feel grateful to money for doing the bare minimum.

From now on, this will be standard. From now on, this will be baseline. From now on,

I will not be surprised at my own ability to provide. That was the birth of her ambition. Not a speech. Not a manifesto. Just a recalibration

of what was acceptable. Fear had taught her: Never again. Watching good women stay hungry had taught her: Not me.

Now money added its own lesson. You are not powerless. Power did not yet mean boards, shares, influence,

titles. It meant: paid. It meant food without begging. Light without pleading.

Exits without permission. The first time money answered, Naomi mistook the sound for peace. It was not peace. It was leverage.

But in a world where she had known only pleading, scarcity, and the virtue of feminine disappearance, even leverage felt holy.

She did not know yet that the same sound would one day drown out her softer parts. She only knew what it felt like to hear a bill knock on the door

and realize, for the first time, that hunger did not have to win every argument.

Chapter 5

The Men Who Called It Love

The Men Who Called It Love

Naomi learned that some men did not offer love. They offered shelter with locks only they could open. By the time men started noticing her properly, Naomi had already learned two languages. Money.

Hunger. Love arrived speaking a third. At first, it sounded beautiful. You work so hard. Let me spoil you.

You shouldn't have to worry about these things. With me, you can finally rest. You don't have to be strong all the time. I've got you. Other women heard those words

and melted. Naomi heard them and reached for her calculator. Not the physical one. The one in her chest. The one that counted costs

no one else seemed willing to name. What do you want in return? What happens if I say no? Whose name will be on the lease? Who holds the exits?

Men admired her ambition before they resented it. They loved the story. A woman who came from little. A woman who worked hard.

A woman who knew the value of things. A woman who did not wait for someone to save her. It made them feel generous to praise it.

"You're so driven."

"I love that about you."

“You’re not like other women,
always waiting for a man.”

“You have your own.”

“You’re a boss.”

They said this over dinners they insisted on paying, in backseats they called Uber Comfort, in apartments with views they hoped would impress her into softness. But admiration had a limit.

It usually arrived right where her independence refused to surrender. The first time it happened, she almost missed it. He was charming.

Stable. Kind in the way people are kind when they still believe you will eventually fold into their script. He liked her mind. Asked about her work.

Bragged about her to his friends.

“She’s serious.

She’s not playing. She’s on my level.” Naomi listened, curious. Where, exactly,

was his level? He had a good job. A plan. A flat he paid for. He knew the names of his bills.

He spoke the language of provider fluent and smooth.

“You don’t have to worry about anything with me,”

he said one night, menu in hand.

“Order whatever you want.

I’ve got it.” Naomi ordered what she wanted. Not the cheapest. Not the most expensive. Just what she liked.

He smiled, pleased. Later, over dessert she did not finish, he leaned in.

“You should move in.”

She raised a brow.

“That’s fast.”

He laughed, as if she were being cute.

“You’re always working.

You’re always stressed. Why pay rent when you could be with me? Save that money. Let me take care of you.” The words landed heavy.

Take care of you. In the house Naomi came from, care had always come with strings. In the church she grew up in, care had often been another word

for control people could feel good about. Her pulse picked up.

“What does take care of me mean to you?”

He blinked, surprised she needed clarification.

“It means you relax.

You don’t have to split everything. You don’t have to kill yourself working. You let me cover things. I’m a man. That’s what I’m here for.”

Naomi smiled. Small. Tight.

“And if we break up?”

He frowned.

“What?”

“If this doesn’t work.

If we fight. If you change your mind. If I do. If I leave. Or you ask me to.

What happens to the woman who moved into your life and stopped building her own exits?” He shifted in his seat.

“Is this a test?”

Everything is a test, Naomi thought. Out loud, she said,

“I just like to know the terms

of whatever contract I’m signing.” It was the wrong word for him. Contract. He recoiled.

“I’m not trying to control you.

I’m trying to love you.” There it was. The confusion Naomi had learned to detect in older men, preachers,

caring relatives. Control disguised as care. Ownership disguised as protection. Access disguised as affection. Love,

in many male mouths, sounded like a purchase order. Naomi shook her head.

“I’m not moving in with any man

whose kindness depends on me needing him more than I need my own salary.” He went quiet. Then came the names. Not immediately.

Not that night. At first, he tried to be patient.

“You’ve been through stuff.

I get it. I’ll prove I’m not like them. You’ll see.” But every time she insisted on paying her part,

every time she ordered her own ride, every time she refused to cancel a meeting for a midweek sleepover, he felt more insulted.

“You don’t know how to receive,” he said once,

when she slid her card onto the bill. Naomi smiled.

“I know exactly how to receive.

I just also know how to leave.” He stared.

“You act like I’m trying to trap you.”

She did not say what she was thinking. You might not be trying, but if I give up my exits, someone will eventually use them against me. The break-up was not dramatic.

It was tired.

“You’re cold.”

“You don’t trust anyone.”

“You make everything about control.”

“You’re impossible to love properly.”

“No man is going to stay

if you keep treating him like a threat.” Naomi nodded.

“Maybe.”

Better a man leave because I refused to be owned than stay on the condition that I shrink. He called her selfish. She filed it under names women receive

when their standards interfere with male convenience. Other men came with different packaging. Some were generous in ways that made sense even to her.

They paid without making it a performance. They offered help without demanding access. They suggested plans without acting entitled to her time. Not all of them were villains. Some were sincerely kind.

But Naomi had learned to hear locks in the softest sentences. Move in with me, so you can rest. Take time off. I'll cover you.

You don't need to work so hard. Let me carry it. For other women, this sounded like relief. For Naomi, it sounded like risk. Dependence felt like a slow leak.

One day, you realize you have built a life you cannot afford to leave. Naomi promised herself she would never wake up in that position.

So she paid her own share. Always. Even when she earned less. Even when he insisted. Even when people called it pride.

Sometimes she let a man pay, but not without clarifying the terms.

"This is a gift, yes?

Not a down payment." They laughed, called her dramatic. But she watched their faces when she said it.

The ones who flinched, she noted. They were the ones who had grown up believing that money was a form of leadership. And leadership, in their minds,

came with obedience pre-installed. Naomi refused to live under that theology. She also refused certain addresses. There was one man, older,

established, sincere. He loved God. Paid his bills. Spoke of family with warmth.

Every woman in Naomi's life approved. He offered what most people would call security.

"Come live here," he said,

showing her a house with soft light and clean lines.

"You can focus on what you want.

You won't have to worry about rent. We'll build something together." Naomi walked through the rooms. They were beautiful. Spacious.

Quiet. Well-kept. She imagined a version of herself living there. Cooking. Hosting.

Working from a desk overlooking a yard. Perhaps eventually rocking a child to sleep. The image was not ugly. But beneath it,

her old math ran its numbers. Whose name is on the deed? Whose money paid for this? Who has more to lose if I leave? What happens if I start to hate this life?

What happens if he changes? Her throat tightened. He noticed.

"What's wrong?"

She shook her head.

"Nothing.

And everything." His brow creased.

"Naomi,

you can't live your whole life waiting for the worst." She almost laughed. She was not waiting for the worst. She was remembering it.

She was remembering her mother standing in kitchens that did not belong to her. She was remembering women who whispered, We cannot leave. Where would we go?

She was remembering how quickly love turned into leverage when a woman could not afford her own exit.

"I can't move into a house

I can't easily move out of," she said softly. He thought she was joking.

"You're overthinking."

“No,” Naomi said.

“I’m just refusing to underthink.”

It was not fair to him. He had not done anything wrong. But in her body, security felt too close to dependence. Safety felt too close to surrender.

He tried to understand. Tried to reassure. Tried not to take it personally. But at some point, exhaustion set in.

“You talk about freedom like it’s God,”

he said. Naomi looked at him. Freedom had certainly answered more prayers than some of the men she had dated. They grew apart.

People said she had trust issues. That she was traumatised. That she did not know how to receive love. That she would end up alone if she kept treating every man

like a potential captor. Maybe. But Naomi had seen too many good women confuse captivity with covenant. She refused to repeat it.

Slowly, a pattern formed. Men who admired her ambition as long as it remained charming, contained, and slightly below theirs.

Men who applauded her independence until it meant she could say no without financial fear. Men who found her standards inspiring until those standards meant

they did not automatically qualify. Men who called their controlling questions concern. Where are you? Who is there?

Why are you working so late? Why do you have to go on that trip? Why don’t you let me handle this? Men who framed boundaries as insults. You don’t trust me.

You’re too guarded. You make me feel like the enemy. You’re always ready to leave. You keep your own money like you’re planning

for the end. Naomi did not deny it.

She was planning for the end. Not because she expected failure. Because she refused to be trapped if it came. In a world where men could walk out and rebuild without stigma,

women who prepared exits were called faithless. Naomi accepted the label. Better faithless to men than faithless to herself.

The names came, as they had to. Cold. Difficult. Too much.

Too calculating. Impossible to love. Impossible to lead. Masculine. Afraid of intimacy.

Married to her career. Heartless. What people rarely said out loud was the second half of their complaint. She is hard to control.

That was the real crime. Not that she wanted money. But that money had made her unreliable as a dependent. They could not threaten her with homelessness.

They could not shame her with who paid the bills. They could not buy submission with dinners and rent. So they called her names instead. Naomi heard them all.

Some nights, they landed. She wondered if she had gone too far. If her fear had turned into arrogance. If her standards were walls or wisdom.

But whenever she imagined doing it their way, she saw her mother at that table. She saw good women eating last. She saw girls becoming mothers before they ever became themselves.

She saw houses where a man's income gave him the right to raise his voice. And she remembered: the first time money answered, she had heard control

and called it peace. The men who came offering love with locks, no matter how kindly, no matter how softly, were echoing that same sound.

Naomi decided she would rather be called cold than be warm in a cage. Let them say she was difficult. Let them complain that she paid her own half. That she kept her own account.

That she refused to move into houses she could not leave. That she asked, What happens if this ends? before saying yes.

Let them call it pride. Naomi knew better. She knew what it looked like when a woman had to stay because the exit was too expensive.

She knew what it felt like when love was debt with kisses. So when men called their control care, their conditions protection, their supervision concern,

their financial offers romance, Naomi smiled politely, held her own keys, and chose, again and again,

to love from a place where hunger could no longer be used against her.

Chapter 6

The Mother She Refused to Become

Naomi did not hate children. She hated the way motherhood was used as evidence in the trial of a woman's goodness. People assumed it was the same thing. They saw a woman in her thirties with no stroller, no toys in her car, no small hand reaching for hers, and decided they knew her heart. Cold. Career-obsessed. Immature. Incomplete. Scared. Selfish.

They never saw the way she bent down to tie a niece's shoes. The way she sat on church steps listening to a child explain a drawing. The way she carried a friend's sleeping toddler out of a noisy room like something too precious to jostle. Children did not frighten her. What frightened her was the script that followed them. The script that said a woman's life reached its true meaning only when she produced another one. It began quietly.

At first, the questions were soft. Do you like kids? Of course. You're so good with them. The way they cling to you, you'll make a wonderful mother. Naomi smiled. People meant it as a compliment. She knew that. But under the praise, she heard expectation.

The same way you can hear a train coming long before it reaches the station. Later, the questions lost their shyness. So, when are you having children? Time is passing. You know biology doesn't wait. Your career won't keep you warm at night. You don't want to end up old and alone. Having it all is a myth. At some point, you have to choose. Choose what? Naomi did not say it out loud.

She knew the answer anyway. Choose between belonging to herself and belonging to a role. Her mother had a line she liked to use

whenever Naomi pushed back. One day you'll understand when you're a mother.

Naomi heard it as both blessing and threat. She knew what her mother meant. Children rearrange you. Love changes you. Sacrifice feels different when it is your own child. Naomi believed that. She did not doubt the depth of maternal love.

She had seen it up close in casseroles, late nights, doctor visits, wrinkled hands counting out coins for school trips. Her refusal was not contempt for that love. It was clarity about the cost. I do not want to understand suffering by inheriting it, Naomi thought. She had already played mother once.

She did not need another chance. In her childhood house, she had been third parent without the title. Watching bills. Translating letters. Checking on her mother's mood. Walking on emotional eggshells. Soothing younger cousins. Managing crises beyond her age. By the time she was a teenager, she had already done enough emotional labor to last a lifetime. She knew what it felt like to be responsible for everyone without anyone being fully responsible for her.

The world called that a strong daughter. Naomi called it training for a kind of motherhood she never wanted to repeat. She had seen women become mothers before they ever became themselves. Girls who skipped their own becoming to accommodate a man's timeline, a church's doctrine, a family's expectations. Women who never had a season that was only theirs.

No era where their time belonged primarily to their own growth. No room to discover who they were when no one needed feeding, comfort, answers. They went from daughter to partner to mother without ever standing alone long enough to know what they actually wanted. The world called it a beautiful story. She called it a missing chapter.

Naomi refused to let her life skip itself. When friends announced pregnancies, she showed up. She bought gifts. She rubbed backs. She cooked. She sat in hospital rooms holding tiny hands, feeling something unmistakably tender move through her. Love did not bypass her. But during baby showers, between games and prayers and cake,

someone always turned to her. You're next. You'll see. It'll change you. It's different when it's your own. Your heart will soften. You'll understand what all this is for. She smiled politely. Inside, she tightened. Why is motherhood spoken about like a moral upgrade?

Why is a woman without children always spoken to like someone awaiting completion? No one said it plainly, but the message was there. A career is nice. A marriage is good. But motherhood, that is the real crown. The way they spoke, you would think a womb was a courtroom and a child was the verdict that declared a woman worthy.

Naomi's problem was not babies. It was trials. She hated watching motherhood used as evidence. Evidence that a woman was not selfish. Evidence that she was capable of sacrifice. Evidence that she was healed. Evidence that she had matured. Evidence that she was what God always intended. What does that make women without children?

Naomi did not like the answers she heard in the pauses. Incomplete. Bitter. Unlucky. Too picky. Too traumatized. Unwomanly. Once, at a family gathering, an older aunt pulled her aside. Naomi, you can't spend your whole life chasing money. Who will look after you when you're old? Who will carry your name? You don't want to end up one of those women with all the handbags and no one to love them. Naomi kept her face calm.

Inside, she wanted to ask, Who is looking after the women with children and no rest? Whose name do they carry when they no longer recognize themselves? Why is a woman with no children considered

tragic, and a woman with no self considered holy? She said none of that. She had learned which truths were unwelcome at family tables. Instead, she set boundaries in quieter ways.

She did not date men who spoke about “giving her children” like a gift that would redeem her ambition. She did not sit through sermons that framed motherhood as the only evidence of femininity without mentally stepping back. She did not attend every event that assumed a woman without children had more time, more energy, more availability. She made decisions that people called selfish because they did not align with the narrative. Once, in a small group, someone said,

A woman without children always has a hardened heart somewhere. Naomi felt it like a slap. She went home, lay on her bed, and stared at the ceiling. Is my heart hard? She tested it.

Thought of the children she loved. The ones she checked on. The ones she protected in subtle ways. The ones whose names she brought to God without their parents ever knowing. Thought of the women she had helped, quietly, with rent, with groceries, with babysitting so they could rest for one evening. Thought of her own mother, whose life had been burned at both ends by duty, and how much she had tried to honor her without repeating her.

If this is a hard heart, Naomi thought, then perhaps what the world calls soft is just a heart that has never learned to say no. She did not want to become a mother because someone else needed her to complete their idea of a good woman. She did not want to bring a child into a life she was still wrestling into shape.

She did not want to repeat cycles of scarcity, resentment, silent sacrifice. She did not want to stand over a stove after a ten-hour day, feeding a family and being told she was “so strong” while nobody asked if she wanted another script. Naomi wanted to belong to herself before she belonged to anyone else. Fully. Without apology. To know

what a day felt like when her body, time, money, and attention were not owed.

To see who she became when no one needed her as a default. To find out if she even liked the version of herself the world kept insisting on turning her into. This did not mean she closed the door forever. She left it ajar in one place only, not for expectation, but for choice.

If she ever became a mother, it would be because she chose it. Not because she surrendered to pressure. Not because her biological clock was shamed into alarms. Not because someone's prophecy backed her into a corner. Because she had looked at herself, looked at her life, looked at the world, and said, Yes, I am willing to stretch this love in that direction. Until then, she refused to perform longing for something she was not sure she wanted.

People called that unnatural. They said a woman who did not ache for babies had something wrong with her. Naomi found it stranger that so many women ached for themselves and were told to ignore it. If there was anything unnatural to her,

it was how easily the world convinced women that their bodies were owed. Owed to men. Owed to tradition. Owed to lineage. Owed to nations that wanted higher birth rates. Owed to churches that needed more Sunday school stories about Hannahs and Sarahs and miraculous wombs. Naomi did not want her body to be evidence. She wanted it to be home. A place where she could live without trial.

So when people said, You'll regret this, one day you'll be lonely, you'll die with no one at your bedside, she thought, Better lonely by consequence of my choices than resentful because I obeyed everyone else's.

Better to grieve what I chose not to have than to resent the lives I brought into a world just to prove I was capable of love. Naomi did not hate children. She hated that motherhood had been turned into a

weapon used primarily against women who dared to imagine a life

where their hearts belonged to God, to work, to art, to friends, to themselves, without needing a child to make that devotion count. If that hatred made her unnatural, she decided she could live with the verdict. She would rather be called unnatural

than become another mother who disappeared so completely that her children grew up learning that goodness for women meant never quite belonging to themselves at all.

Chapter 7

Expensive Rooms

Expensive rooms were quiet, but Naomi learned that quiet was not always the same as peace. By the time she realized this, she had already climbed into a life that looked, from the outside, like everything she once needed. Soft hotel carpets. Keycards that opened onto views instead of threats. Airport lounges with filtered air and filtered people. Conference stages where her name appeared on screens. Apartments with doors that closed firmly and locks only she could open. Naomi walked through these spaces with the posture of someone who remembered what it cost to arrive.

She had receipts. Not just financial ones. Years of late nights. Risk. Humiliation swallowed in boardrooms. Skills sharpened under pressure. Lines drawn with trembling hands that eventually stopped shaking. Everywhere she went, there was evidence. Emails. Contracts. Invitations. Flights booked in her own name with her own card. She had done this.

One evening, standing in a hotel room high above a city that once felt too big for her, Naomi placed her palms on the cold glass and whispered, I built this. She said it softly. Not as a boast. As a fact she needed to hear. Because for years, the house of origin had made her feel like she owed her existence to other people's choices.

Now, there was nobody else to credit. No landlord. No husband. No benefactor. Just a woman with spreadsheets, intuition, and an almost religious commitment to never being at hunger's mercy again. She liked the way expensive rooms respected boundaries. Do not disturb signs meant something here. Staff knocked and waited. Noise lived mostly outside.

In these spaces, no one barged in to demand what else she could cut, stretch, sacrifice. Her childhood house had never known that kind of respect. Silence, back then, was full of held breath. Here, silence seemed to obey her. Yet, something felt off.

The first sign was how relief had replaced joy. Deals closed. Numbers hit. Milestones met. People clapped. Sent emails. Posted about her. Naomi smiled where required, stood for photos, accepted congratulations. But when doors closed behind her, what she felt was not celebration.

It was exhale. Not, I'm so happy. More, Thank God I didn't fail. Thank God I can pay everyone. Thank God I can keep my distance. Thank God the numbers line up. Achievement had become another bill.

Her success wasn't just a dream fulfilled. It was a system she had to keep funded. She noticed it in airports. Other people saw airports as transitions. Naomi saw them as proof.

Proof that she could leave whenever she wanted. Proof that she was not trapped in any one place. Proof that she could outfly old ghosts. She loved the anonymity. Suitcase. Ticket. Passport. Name on a screen. No one there knew the girl counting coins. No one there knew the house that counted everything. No one there knew how many vows had been made over late bills. She belonged fully to herself in transit.

Still, sitting in lounges with free coffee, soft chairs, and endless outlets, Naomi sometimes caught herself staring at nothing. The same hunger that had once clawed at her over unpaid notices had changed shape. It now asked questions with different vocabulary.

If this is safety, why does it still feel so conditional? If this is freedom, why do you still fear losing it? If this is success, why does it only feel real when you're working? Some expensive rooms felt unnervingly familiar. Not because they looked like the house she

grew up in. Because they behaved like it. In one boardroom, glass walls, long table, cityscape outside,

she sat with people who controlled more money than her childhood neighborhood would see in a decade. They talked about risk, growth, strategy. Half the words were new. All the dynamics were old. Power sat on specific chairs. Voices carried more weight if they came with certain titles. Gratitude was expected from anyone allowed in.

Naomi spoke when it counted. Listened when it was wise. But somewhere between a slide about projections and a joke about “tough quarters,” she realized: this, too, is a house that counts everything. Not coins on a kitchen table. But numbers on screens. Hours. Outputs. Deliverables. Loyalty.

She knew the feeling. There were still good women here too. They wore heels instead of house slippers, blazers instead of aprons. They stayed late. Smiled. Softened their tone. Took on the invisible labor of making men look competent. They were praised for being team players. For going above and beyond.

Naomi watched and thought, Different currency. Same hunger. She had promised herself she would never be that woman again. Yet sometimes, she caught herself sliding toward it. Taking on one extra task. Soothing someone’s ego. Making herself a little smaller to keep peace in rooms that called it professionalism.

That was when she doubled down. Raised her rates. Clarified her terms. Said no to opportunities that came with too much access to her time, not enough respect for her limits. People called it boundaries. She called it self-rescue. Still, the higher she climbed,

the fewer people she trusted to stand beside her without agenda. Money had bought distance. It had not decided who could approach. So she curated. Invites. Dinners. Phone calls.

She answered less. Travelled more. Kept her circle tight. From the outside, it looked like discernment. From the inside, it sometimes felt like isolation with beautiful lighting. Her apartment testified to the tension. Everything was intentional.

Furniture chosen for comfort and longevity. Kitchen stocked with what she liked, not just what was on sale. Art on walls that did not belong to anyone else's taste. Books stacked without apology. She loved this space. Loved unlocking a door and knowing every bill attached to it had her name. Loved the way the floor did not creak under other people's footsteps. Loved the absence of shouted arguments through walls.

But there were nights when the quiet pressed in. When she realized she had gotten exactly what she had once prayed for, and still felt a familiar tightness. Not fear of eviction. Fear of collapse.

Not of finances. Of self. Because somewhere along the way, Naomi had tethered her sense of worth to her ability to maintain this life. If she lost it, who would she be? Not a hungry girl.

But not this woman either. The thought unnerved her. So she worked. Work was how she prayed for continued safety. Work was how she kept the ghosts at bay.

When people said, You deserve this, relax, enjoy, she tried. Spa weekends. Vacations. Dinners with no agenda. Yet even there, inside luxury,

she heard echoes. The way a waiter looked at her when she signed the bill without hesitation. The way hotel staff used ma'am with a respect that still felt like borrowed costume. The way men made comments about her lifestyle. Must be nice. Soft life. You're living. She smiled. Inside, another tally.

Soft life did not feel soft. It felt like armor upgraded. More beautiful. More expensive. Still armor. There was a night, after a particularly large contract, where the contrast hit hardest.

She had closed a deal that would have made her younger self cry with relief. The numbers were public. The congratulations loud. She returned to yet another beautiful room, set her phone on the nightstand, and sat on the edge of the bed. The city was a line of lights. The room smelled faintly of some neutral hotel fragrance.

She should have been thrilled. Instead, tears came without warning. Not sobs. Just a quiet leak from somewhere she thought she had sealed. She pressed her fingers to her eyes, annoyed.

This is what you wanted, she told herself. This is what that girl in the counting house promised herself. Exits. Keys. Silence. You have them. Why does your chest still hurt?

The answer was not immediate. But as she sat there, breathing, she realized: money had solved certain problems so completely that she had begun to believe

it would eventually solve all of them. It had not. It had bought locks. Not rest. It had bought doors. Not belonging. It had bought exits. Not roots.

It had removed hunger from her table. It had not removed hunger from her soul. The emptiness was not about lack anymore. It was about distance. From people she no longer fully trusted. From communities that could not handle her complexity. From the girl she used to be and still carried like a ghost. She got up, walked to the window, looked down at the city.

Once, this view would have been enough to quiet everything. Now, she understood its limits. Expensive rooms could shelter her from old storms. They could not protect her from herself. She ran a hand along the glass.

The reflection looking back was not the hero of a scarcity story. It was a woman who had built a life so controlled that anything unexpected

felt like threat. Security had been her salvation. She was beginning to suspect it might also become her prison. The thought terrified her.

Not because she regretted what she had built. But because she realized that even here, in rooms she paid for, in lives she curated,

she was still answering to the same old vow: Never again. Never hungry. Never helpless. Never dependent. Never again.

It had carried her this far. It might not be able to carry her further without turning the fortress she built into a cage.

Standing there, Naomi understood that the next chapter of her life would not be about earning more or loving less. It would be about discovering

whether she could ever feel safe in a world where security was no longer her only definition of salvation.

Chapter 8

Hunger in Designer Clothes

Hunger in Designer Clothes

Hunger did not leave Naomi when the money came. It learned how to dress better. On paper, she had outrun the life that raised her. Accounts with padding. Savings that could hold an emergency without breaking.

A calendar filled with work she had chosen. Rooms she paid for without bargaining. From a distance, it looked like the opposite of lack. Up close, the old hunger was still there, just better groomed.

It no longer stood at cupboards counting portions. It stood at checkout screens, calculating risk. Every purchase was a negotiation. Not just,

Can I afford this? But, How many exits does this cost me? How many months of safety am I handing over? How quickly can I rebuild

if everything falls apart? Naomi wore beautiful things. Not as costume. As proof. Shoes that did not blister her.

Coats that held their shape for years. Bags that did not peel. Pieces that would have once belonged only on the bodies of women she used to stare at from buses.

She chose them carefully. Not for logos alone. For longevity. For the way they whispered to the girl inside her:

You are no longer cheap in anyone's hands. But even there, in dressing rooms with flattering mirrors, hunger came along.

It stood beside her as she turned from side to side, commenting. If you lost all this, what would matter more? The item,

or the evidence that you once could buy it? Are you buying clothing, or reassurance? She handed the card over anyway. Sometimes the reassurance was worth the price.

Other times, she walked away. Not from lack. From discipline. Her restraint was not stinginess. It was fear in a blazer.

Because even with full accounts, Naomi's mind still ran end-of-month simulations. What if contracts stop? What if a crisis comes? What if someone sues?

What if I get sick? What if I cannot outwork this? She had lived too many years in houses where one event wiped out everything.

Her nervous system did not forget that math. So she saved. Sometimes excessively. Sometimes to the point where friends teased her.

"Live a little," they said.

"You can relax now.

You've made it." Naomi smiled. Relaxation felt like a luxury she had not yet earned. She did rest.

On paper. Days blocked off. Out-of-office replies. Trips booked for no reason other than joy. But even there,

hunger sat beside her. Not the hunger for food. The hunger for guarantee. On a beach, she checked emails just in case. In bed, she ran through budgets before sleep.

On a Sunday, she found herself checking markets instead of exhaling. When she tried to do nothing, guilt arrived quickly. Rest felt suspicious.

In her childhood, rest had been associated with danger. Rest meant you were not hustling. Rest meant someone might accuse you of laziness. Rest meant you trusted that tomorrow would not betray you.

Naomi did not fully trust tomorrow. Not yet. So she filled her days with usefulness. Even pleasure had to justify itself. A massage was not indulgence.

It was recovery. A vacation was not escape. It was strategy: prevent burnout, return sharper.

Hunger had learned to speak corporate. It wore productivity apps. Attended goal-setting retreats. Drafted visions. Curated habits.

It did not scream in cupboards anymore. It whispered through spreadsheets. You are still one disaster away from the beginning. Stay ready.

Stay sharp. Stay ahead. Love did not escape this scrutiny. Naomi tried to receive it. She met people who did not want to own her.

Friends who showed up without asking what she could offer. Men who did not flinch at her independence. Mentors who wanted her good more than her usefulness.

She appreciated them. But even as they drew close, she listened for the clause. What will this cost if I let it in? What do they expect if I fail?

Will they still love me if I lose this lifestyle? Will they resent me if I stop being impressive? Hunger had taught her that every gift could turn into leverage. So she weighed people like she weighed contracts.

Measured their reactions. Tested their silences. Watched how they spoke about others behind their backs. Only the rare ones passed.

Even then, full trust was slow. Because beneath every interaction, the old ledger still hummed. Who owes what? Who has given more?

Where is the power? Once, sitting at an expensive brunch with a friend from a similar background, Naomi watched a woman walk by outside the window. Stroller.

Plastic bags. Child tugging at her sleeve. Face tired in the way Naomi recognized. She stared longer than was polite. Her friend noticed.

“You okay?”

Naomi swallowed.

“Yes.

No. I don’t know.” Because looking at that woman, she felt three things at once. Compassion,

for the weight she could see. Fear, that a few different choices or circumstances could have made that her story. And a defensive superiority,

the sharp thought: That will never be me. I paid too much to avoid it. She hated that last part. Hated how hunger had made her protective

to the point of arrogance. As if avoiding one form of pain made her morally above those who could not. She caught herself. This is hunger,

she realized. Hunger for distinction. Hunger for proof that she had truly escaped. Hunger to believe

she would never slip back. It wore designer shoes. Ordered oat lattes. Spoke about boundaries. But underneath,

it was the same hunger that once made her hide coins in secret envelopes. This new hunger did not hoard food. It hoarded status.

Numbers.

Invites. Followers. Respect. Rooms. She measured safety not only in bank balances, but in how irreplaceable she felt. If she became forgettable, would the world punish her by taking away what she had built?

It was an absurd belief. She knew that. But trauma rarely asks for rational permission. At conferences, she watched panels of women speak about resilience, excellence, leadership. She listened. Learned.

Nodded. But sometimes, during applause, she wondered how many of them were also driven secretly by the same fear:

that if they stopped, the ground would open. Hunger had also found its way into her standards. She did not want just enough. She wanted assurance.

Work had to be meaningful. People had to be trustworthy. Churches had to be honest. Romance had to be sincere. None of that was wrong.

But the way she enforced it sometimes isolated her. She filtered so ruthlessly that only a few ever got close. She called it discernment.

Sometimes it was. Sometimes it was hunger in protective clothing. Protective against disappointment. Protective against repetition.

Protective against any scenario that smelled like the house she came from. If a situation remotely resembled old patterns, a leader who wanted her labour without fair pay, a friend who always needed but rarely gave,

a man who subtly tested how quickly she would adjust her life to his, she cut it off. Fast. Clean.

People said she was harsh. Naomi heard her own defence: I have already lived the consequences of ignoring early warning signs. Still, in quiet moments,

she admitted: Not every exit is wisdom. Some exits are just hunger running ahead to avoid ever feeling helpless again. She saw it most clearly

when she was alone. On nights when the numbers were fine, the city calm, her body rested, and yet

her mind still scanned for threats. An unanswered email. A tone misread. A slight downturn in a chart. A headline about recession.

Each small thing registered with disproportionate weight. This is what happens when hunger does not heal, she realized. It recruits everything:

luxury, discipline, standards, intellect, and turns them into soldiers.

Hunger in designer clothes is still hunger. It just gets invited into better rooms. One afternoon, after signing another contract, Naomi walked past a storefront window.

Her reflection looked back. Tailored coat. Clean lines. Eyes alert. She saw, suddenly,

both versions at once. The girl counting coins. The woman counting risks. Different wardrobes. Same posture.

Back straight. Jaw set. Hands ready to catch whatever fell. She stopped, hand on glass,

and whispered,

“You survived.”

The reflection did not soften. It tilted its head, as if to ask: At what point do we stop living like survival is the only goal?

She had no answer yet. All she knew was that hunger had been a faithful protector and a merciless master. It had kept her alive.

It had kept her sharp. It had also kept her from fully tasting anything without checking its expiry date. The money had changed the landscape. But the voice inside still spoke

with the same urgency: Be ready to run.

Chapter 9

The People She Used

The People She Used

Naomi had been hurt by hunger, but hunger had also taught her how to hurt without calling it cruelty. For a long time, she did not see it that way.

She saw herself as cautious. Selective. Boundaried. Wise. Other people saw scars.

It began with small things. A favour taken for granted. A call ignored. A promise left vague enough to wriggle out of.

Naomi told herself she was protecting capacity. The truth was less flattering. Sometimes, she was using people. Not for sport. Not with malice.

Simply because a part of her had learned that everything and everyone could be turned into strategy. Friends became shields.

The first time Naomi realized this was not during business. It was during a late-night call. A friend, one of the few who had known her

before the expensive rooms, called crying. A breakup. A disappointment. A life detour she had not chosen.

Naomi listened. She gave advice. Comforted. Sent money without being asked. She was not heartless.

But somewhere during the conversation, when the friend said,

“I don’t know what I’d do without you,”

Naomi felt a small, ugly relief. Being needed meant being central. Being central meant being safe. If people needed her,

they were less likely to leave. Hunger had taught her that usefulness was a kind of insurance. So she leaned into it. She became the friend people called in crisis.

Offering couches. Solutions. Contacts. Tough love. Money.

They called her solid. Strong. A rock. Dependable. She liked the titles.

What she did not admit was that sometimes she held people close only while their need matched her capacity. When they began to ask for more,

for her vulnerability, for her time outside emergencies, for her presence when they were not falling apart, she grew distant. She answered slower.

Changed topics.

Rescheduled

until the friendship thinned. Naomi told herself it was boundaries. Sometimes it was. Sometimes it was simply an unwillingness to offer tenderness

without crisis as justification. Gentleness felt expensive. She rationed it. In her work, Naomi eventually hired help. An assistant.

Bright. Eager. Loyal. At first, Naomi treated her like an investment. Taught her.

Paid fairly. Encouraged boundaries. Spoke proudly about giving another woman a chance to avoid the kind of scarcity she had grown up in.

It sounded beautiful. But when pressure came, tight deadlines, high-stakes projects, travel stacked on travel,

Naomi slipped. She expected availability. Longer hours. Emotional steadiness. She framed it as the industry.

Everyone does this. This is how we learn. This is the cost. Her assistant rarely complained. She organised flights.

Smoothed schedules. Shielded Naomi from minor inconveniences. Reminded her to eat. One night, after a particularly intense week,

Naomi found a message. It was long. Careful. Respectful. It said, in essence:

I am grateful for this job. I have learned a lot. But sometimes, I feel like a buffer rather than a person. Sometimes, your emergencies

become my normal. Sometimes, I cover for you in ways that leave me empty. I admire your boundaries. I wish you would allow me

the same. Naomi's chest tightened. Her first instinct was defence. Had she not been generous? Had she not paid well?

Had she not warned her about the pace? But beneath the arguments, a quieter truth pushed forward. She had used this woman as a shield.

Shield from logistics. Shield from discomfort. Shield from the consequences of saying yes to too much. Naomi replied.

She apologized. Adjusted expectations. Reassigned tasks. Raised pay. Encouraged time off.

It was sincere. It was also late. Something in the trust had shifted. They continued working together. Professionally, they functioned.

Personally, a distance remained. Naomi filed that away. Hunger had not only taught her to work hard. It had taught her to normalise

other people's sacrifice if it protected her own stability. In love, Naomi had her own ways of using people. Not for money. Not for

status.

For proof. Proof that she could be desired. Proof that she could leave. Proof that she had changed. She entered relationships like someone

testing a bridge they never intended to fully trust. When things were good, she held back. When things felt risky, she left. She avoided the middle ground

where honest conversation might have transformed both of them. Instead, she watched. Meticulously. Measuring reactions.

Testing patience. Pushing lightly against boundaries to see what would crack first. Men thought she was playing games. In reality, she was running scenarios.

How does he react to my success? How does he handle my no? Does he try to buy control? Does he collapse without input? If they failed quickly, she left quickly.

No explanation. No ugly breakup scenes. Just distance. If they passed for a while, she waited.

As soon as the relationship required vulnerability beyond her comfort, she found reasons to go. Busyness. Mismatch.

Different seasons. Not aligned. The phrases were socially acceptable. They were also sometimes dishonest. Because the real reason was simpler.

She was not willing to let anyone see how much of her life was still governed by fear. It felt safer to let them think she was cold

than to let them see she was still that girl who could not trust any love that did not come itemized. In the process, she hurt people.

Men who had shown up patiently. Men who had respected her pace. Men who had been transparent about their weaknesses and still found themselves cut off

because Naomi panicked at the first sign of dependency. She did not call it cruelty. She called it self-preservation. But in the quiet, she remembered faces.

A man who asked,

“Can you at least tell me what changed?”

And she could not give him an answer that did not implicate her own terror. There were people who had opened doors for Naomi. Older women.

Older men. Leaders who had seen her potential and decided to risk their own reputations by attaching her name to rooms she had not yet earned alone.

She respected them. But at times, she also treated them more like opportunities than relationships. When their counsel aligned with her plans,

she was grateful. When their counsel challenged her pace, her methods, her motives, she disappeared.

Not outright. Just slower replies. Fewer updates. Less eye contact. More distance.

She would tell herself, People have seasons. Not every mentor is for every stage. True. But sometimes, the truth was this:

she did not want to hear that the hunger which had made her impressive might now be hurting her. One mentor, a woman who had survived her own transformation from scarcity,

once said to Naomi,

“You remind me of myself

before I realized I was burning people to keep warm.” Naomi laughed it off. Later, she replayed it. Burning people to keep warm.

She had never lit anyone on fire. She had never intentionally destroyed someone. But warmth was a powerful metaphor. Comfort. Safety.

Control. How many times had she maintained those for herself at the cost of someone else's sense of being valued for more than their role? She began to notice patterns.

A friend she only called when overwhelmed. A colleague she vented to but never encouraged. A sibling she kept at arm's length, offering money instead of presence,

advice instead of empathy, solutions instead of listening. Naomi did not like neediness. It reminded her too much of her own past. So she punished it.

Not with cruelty. With distance. Again, she named it boundary. Again, sometimes it was. Again, sometimes it was not.

At some point, she could no longer ignore the theme. Whenever hunger felt threatened, she reached for people. Not to hold. To use.

To block. To shield. To absorb impact. To make her feel safer, more central,

less at risk. And because she prided herself on being honest, this realisation bothered her deeply. Had she become what she once despised? Someone who treated people like currency?

Not fully. Not always. But enough to matter. The moment that shook her most came from someone she did not expect.

A longstanding friend finally pulled back. Not with a fight. With a decision.

"You have become very good

at naming your boundaries," she said. Naomi nodded, confused.

"That's progress, no?"

“It is,” her friend replied.

“But sometimes it feels like

you use boundaries as walls, not just doors.” Naomi frowned. Her friend continued.

“You say you don’t owe anyone access.

And you’re right. You don’t. But lately, it feels like you’ve also decided you don’t owe anyone tenderness.”

Naomi opened her mouth to argue. Closed it. Because somewhere deep down, the sentence landed. Tenderness had become,

in her economy, a luxury reserved for children, clients in crisis, and the rare few who had known her before money.

Everyone else got efficiency. Clear. Polite. Strategic. It protected her.

It starved them. She sat with that. Naomi had spent so much of her life refusing to be the woman who disappeared into sacrifice,

that she had forgotten there is more than one way to disappear. You can disappear by giving too much. You can also disappear by never giving enough of the parts that make you human.

Hunger had narrowed her. It had made her so focused on survival that she sometimes treated other people’s hearts as collateral. Not always.

Not beyond repair. But enough that she had to admit, out loud, if only to herself: I have used people.

For cover. For proof. For comfort. For distraction. For narrative.

I have called it wisdom. Sometimes, it was. Sometimes, it was just fear wearing the language of self-care. Naming this did not make Naomi

less justified in her boundaries. It made her more responsible for what she did with them. Hunger had hurt her. Hunger had also taught her

how to hurt in ways that sounded reasonable. Freedom built on other people's unpaid emotional labour was not as clean as it looked.

The girl from the counting house had grown up. The woman in the expensive rooms could no longer avoid counting the cost

other people had paid for her never-again.

Chapter 10

The Woman Who Wanted a Child From Her

The hardest requests are not always made by people trying to control you. Sometimes they are made by people who love you and still want a version of you that would cost too much to become. He was not a villain. Naomi had dated men who made control obvious. She knew how to leave them.

This one was different. He did not flinch at her ambition. He did not compete with her success. He did not make jokes about her standards. He met her where she was. Steady job. Quiet faith. A history that had hurt him without making him cruel. Friends who trusted him. A life already in motion before she arrived. Naomi liked that.

He had not been waiting for a woman to give his days meaning. He had meaning. Work. Community. A small rented house with plants that actually lived. Siblings. Nieces and nephews who climbed him like furniture. He had roots in places Naomi had never allowed herself to plant. They met through mutual friends, through one of those unintentional set-ups

where everyone says, It's just dinner, but their faces betray hope. At first, she braced. Waiting for the moment he would reveal the familiar script. You're too much. You work too hard. Let me lead. Let me be a man. He never said it.

Instead, he asked questions. Not the intrusive kind. The curious kind. How did you get from there to here? What did it cost? What do you actually enjoy when you're not working? What scares you that people wouldn't expect? Naomi, who had grown used to being

studied as an example, felt herself relax.

She told him stories she hadn't told in years. About the house that counted everything. About her mother's hands. About coins and vows and the first scholarship. He listened without turning them into a lesson. He did not say, See, God had a plan. He did not say, That's why you should, He just said, That must have been heavy. No wonder you are how you are. She laughed.

How am I? Careful, he said. But not as careful as you think. They built something slow. Texts. Calls. Dinners where she left her phone face down. Walks where her shoulders dropped half an inch. He did not rush to move in. Did not rush to merge accounts. Did not treat her like a project.

Naomi noticed. Her friends did too. You seem different with him, they said. She shrugged. He feels less like a threat, she admitted.

That was new. Months passed. They met families. Survived holidays. Weathered small fights about nothing and one or two about something. He saw how she worked. The pace. The precision. The way she double-checked every exit. He did not shame her for it. Sometimes he even admired it.

You built all this with no safety net, he said once, looking around her apartment. That's no small thing. She swallowed. There were moments she thought, Maybe this is the person I can build a shared life with without drowning.

For a while, they did. Shared weekends. Shared jokes. Shared prayers where he did not reduce God to a provider of husbands and she did not reduce God to a provider of exits. Then, one night, the conversation they had both quietly postponed arrived.

They were at his kitchen table. Dishes pushed aside. Tea cooling. A playlist humming low. He looked strangely nervous. Naomi felt it in her stomach. Here it comes.

He traced a finger along the rim of his mug. Naomi, can I ask you something without you turning it into a test? She tried to laugh. No promises. He smiled.

Fair. He took a breath. Have you thought about children? Ever? With anyone? With... me? The room went still. Not hostile. Not manipulative.

Just still. Naomi watched him. He was not trying to trap her. His eyes did not have that calculating gleam she had learned to spot. They had something else.

Hope. Fear. A softness she rarely saw in men talking about their future. She could have deflected. Maybe one day. Let's see. Why do we have to decide now? But Naomi had promised herself truth, even when it cost her.

So she said it. I've thought about it. He waited. And? And I haven't found a version where I want that life more than I want to belong to myself.

Silence. Not the angry kind. The heavy kind. He nodded slowly. I figured you'd say something like that, he admitted. But I needed to hear it.

Naomi's throat felt tight. What about you? He did not hedge. I want kids. Plural.

Not because I think they'll fix anything. Not because I want someone to look after me when I'm old. Not because I think you're incomplete without them. He looked at her. Because I love the idea of raising people with you. The "with you" landed like a stone. Naomi swallowed.

He continued. You know my family. It's messy. Loud. Exhausting. But I love being Uncle. I love school plays and silly drawings and tiny hands trusting mine. Maybe that's selfish. Maybe it's just my version of never again. I don't want to repeat what I saw. I want to do it

differently.

With you. His voice broke a little on the last word. Naomi looked away. She could picture it. Small shoes by the door. Laughter. Chaos. A life centralized around someone other than herself.

It did not repulse her. It just did not feel like hers. She thought of her mother. Of the women who stayed hungry. Of girls becoming mothers before they became people. Of the way the world used motherhood as proof. She thought of her own carefully built life, the rooms, the exits, the balance,

and felt something like vertigo. He reached for her hand. I need you to know, he said quietly, that this is not me trying to control you. She nodded. I know.

Some part of her wanted to say, That's what makes this worse. Because control was easy to fight. Love was harder. No villain to point to. No obvious manipulation.

Just two people with deeply formed definitions of life, colliding. He squeezed her fingers. If you never want kids, he said slowly, I won't lie and say I'll be fine. I might resent it. I might resent you.

And that's not fair to either of us. Naomi exhaled. She appreciated the honesty. She also felt a familiar blade. Love as equation.

Not because he wanted to buy her. Because he could not amputate his desire for fatherhood without amputating something essential in himself. He was not asking, Become what I want or you're not a real woman. He was asking,

Is there a version of you that could share this with me? Naomi thought about all the versions other people had tried to demand. The good daughter. The good wife. The good mother. The woman who ate last. The woman who stayed. She had refused them to stay alive.

This version, though, came with kindness. He would likely be a gentle father. He would likely change nappies, wake up at night, show

up. He would not leave her alone with the work. That made it harder to say no.

Because now she could not hide behind the excuse that men only wanted to trap her. This man wanted to build with her. Still, the cost felt the same.

Her body. Her time. Her career. Her sleep. Her nervous system. Her sense of being primarily her own. She closed her eyes. In another life, she whispered, maybe. He waited. In this one? he asked.

She opened her eyes. In this one, I can't promise a child to prove love. It wouldn't be a proof, he said softly. It would be a life. She nodded.

And I won't bring a life into a story where I am already resentful at the idea of disappearing. That wouldn't be fair to them. The honesty hung between them. He looked away first. So what do we do? he asked.

There was no neutral option. Stay, and one of them betrayed themselves. Leave, and both carried loss. Naomi had spent a lifetime choosing herself over scripts.

This time, choosing herself meant hurting someone who had never tried to hurt her. That felt different. Later, they would tell people some clean version. We wanted different things. We parted amicably. We're still friends.

Some of it would be true. But in the moment, it was not clean. He cried. She did too. Not loudly. They were both too practiced at composure.

But tears came. For the life that could have been if either of them had been willing to bend more. For the version of Naomi who might have wanted this if she had not spent so many years raising herself from the wreckage. For the version of him who might have chosen love without children

if his own ache had not been shaped by absence. They were not enemies. They were witnesses to each other's limits. Weeks later, her mother called.

She had heard there had been a breakup. Naomi, what happened? He was a good man. You won't find many like him. Naomi said nothing. Her mother continued. One day you will understand when you're a mother.

Naomi's jaw tightened. No, she thought. I understood long ago what happens to women who say yes because they are afraid of regret.

Out loud, she only said, I'm not willing to have a child to keep a man I love. Her mother sighed. You always make everything so complicated. Naomi smiled sadly.

No. The world did. I'm just refusing to simplify my life by lying. Later that night, she lay on her couch, phone face down, lights dim,

and let herself feel the full weight of what she had chosen. Freedom and loss. Autonomy and emptiness. No baby cries. No tiny socks. No immediate family centered around her.

But also no resentment of a child who might one day sense that their existence had been a concession. The hardest requests in her life

had rarely come from the villains. They had come from people who genuinely loved her and still wanted a version of her that would have required the death

of the self she had spent years fighting to protect. Naomi did not hate them for it. She just refused to become

that version for anyone.

Chapter 11

When Security Became a Cage

Naomi had built a life with exits everywhere, then wondered why nothing felt like home. After him, the freedom she chose sat beside her like an empty chair. Her days did not collapse. She did not spiral. She did not run back begging for another chance. She did not suddenly wish for a child she had never wanted.

She kept moving. Meetings. Flights. Emails. Contracts. Gym. Therapy on Thursdays. The machinery of her life kept humming. But something in the rhythm shifted. Silence no longer sounded only like victory.

For years, silence had been the prize. No shouting through walls. No late-night financial arguments. No guilt pressed into every meal. No man slamming doors to remind everyone who paid the rent. Silence meant safety. Now, there were evenings where the quiet felt heavy, as if every cushion, every clean plate, every perfectly arranged shelf

was testifying to how successfully she had arranged her life to need no one. She sat on her own couch, in her own apartment, surrounded by evidence of competence, and realized

she could go days without anyone seeing her unguarded. Not because no one loved her. Because she had built every hallway with exits. Friends knew the time to call her. Clients knew the version they were allowed. Family knew the topics that would end the conversation if they pushed. Everyone had learned her boundaries.

Very few had seen her without them. After the breakup, people asked. How are you? Are you okay? Do you regret it? Do you miss

him? Naomi answered honestly. I'm sad. I miss him. I don't regret not having a child to keep him.

What she did not always add was, I'm starting to wonder what I have lost by designing a life where nothing and no one

can touch me too deeply. At work, she still excelled. Her calendar was efficient. Her projects structured. Her staff respected her. She was generous with pay. Firm with expectations. Clear. But occasionally, in meetings, she caught herself checking out.

Someone would be talking about growth, future, expansion, and her mind would drift. Is this living? she wondered. Or am I just maintaining a fortress? On one trip, she returned to a city that had once felt like arrival.

The same hotel. The same lobby. The same scent. She checked in as always. Credit card. ID. Polite smile. The receptionist recognized her. Welcome back, Ms. Naomi. It's good to see you again.

She nodded, habitually pleased by the continuity. In her room, she placed her suitcase in the usual corner, hung her clothes, set her toiletries in the same formation. Ritual. Predictable. Safe.

That night, lying in a bed that had never known her tears before, she stared at the ceiling and acknowledged something she had been resisting. This routine, this structure, this control had once been the antidote to chaos.

Now, it had become a script so rehearsed that there was no room for anything unexpected. She had avoided dependency. She had also avoided surrender. Not just to men. To God. To friends. To any story that required her to stay

when her instinct was to run. She thought of him. Not as a mistake. As a mirror. He had exposed a limit. Not his. Hers.

The limit of her willingness to be changed by love. She did not regret saying no to motherhood she did not desire. But she began to

ask whether she had also said no to any version of her life

where she did not hold every variable in her hands. Back home, she sat at her dining table, another purchase she had once been proud of, and pulled out a notebook. She wrote a sentence.

What have I built to protect myself that now prevents me from belonging? The answers came in fragments. Predictable routines. Layered savings that made generosity feel dangerous. A reluctance to share keys to her space. Rules about what time people could call. A refusal to need anyone's help without a plan to repay it immediately. A faith that spoke often about trust in God but rarely about trusting people. None of these, on their own, were wrong. Taken together,

they formed a cage. Beautiful. Ethical. Impressive. But still a cage. Naomi remembered how certain women had once been praised

for disappearing into motherhood, and how fiercely she had resisted that script. Now, she saw a strange parallel. She had not disappeared into children. She had disappeared into competence.

Into self-sufficiency. Into control. Different expression. Same risk. A life where her value was tied to what she could carry without dropping anything.

She closed the notebook. This realization did not magically make her reckless. She did not rush to dismantle every boundary. She did not call her ex and say, I've changed my mind.

She did something smaller. She invited a friend over on a Tuesday without cleaning the entire apartment. She left a mug in the sink.

She let the conversation stretch past the time she usually guarded for emails. When her friend left, she felt uneasy. No disaster had occurred. But something in her schedule had shifted. She sat with the discomfort.

Another night, she accepted help. A minor inconvenience, car issues, nothing dramatic. The old Naomi would have handled it

alone. Rideshare. Rental. Problem solved. This time, when a friend said,

I can drive you, it's not a big deal, she hesitated, then said, Okay. Sitting in the passenger seat, her hands doing nothing,

she felt both gratitude and panic. Gratitude, because someone else was there. Panic, because she was not the one controlling the route. She breathed. This is what being known feels like, she thought.

Not just people respecting your independence. People taking some of the weight without asking you to stop being strong. Gradually, small experiments. Sharing more in therapy than stories about the past. Talking about present loneliness, not just old pain. Letting herself say,

I don't know how to build a life where I am safe and still reachable. She did not yet have the answer. But asking the question was new. One Sunday, she went to church and actually stayed after the service.

Not out of duty. Out of curiosity. A woman she barely knew started talking. About bills. About kids. About exhaustion. Naomi felt the old instinct to turn it into advice.

Instead, she listened. Really listened. When the woman finished, she said only, That sounds heavy. I'm sorry you're carrying so much. The woman's eyes filled.

Thank you, she whispered. Most people either try to fix it or tell me to count my blessings. Naomi nodded. She understood that script. Walking home, she realized: for once, she had not used someone's vulnerability as a mirror for her own fear.

She had simply been present. No transaction. No ledger. Perhaps, she thought, this is what security is for, not just to keep danger out,

but to give you enough stability to actually show up without calculating every risk. Naomi was not ready to dismantle her entire

fortress.

But she began to suspect that salvation could not be defined only as safety. Safety had saved her. Now, it was slowly smothering her.

The exits she had built had done their job. They had stopped her from being trapped. But as she sat in her own living room, surrounded by proof

that she could leave anywhere, anytime, she faced a new question: What would it mean to choose to stay? Not in hunger. Not in abuse. Not in scripts that erased her.

But in relationships, places, callings, where she could be seen, risk small disappointments, and still trust that she would not lose herself

if she let someone else be a part of her life's architecture. Naomi had built a life that could not collapse easily. For the first time, she admitted

that the same walls that held her might also be the thing keeping her from ever knowing what home could feel like when it was not defined by how quickly

she could get out.

Chapter 12

The Soft Thing She Did Not Trust

Softness had always looked dangerous to Naomi, because every soft thing she had known had been asked to carry too much. Pillows in houses where sleep was thin. Mothers in families that leaned on them until their backs forgot straightness. Faith in churches that told women to surrender while letting men keep their power. Soft things did not last long in her childhood.

They tore. They broke. They got blamed. So Naomi made herself into something else. Sharp. Prepared. Structured. Hard to move. Now, sitting in a life built on control, she realized

she did not know how to be soft without expecting to be used. So she started small. No grand gestures. No dramatic transformation. Just experiments. The first one came disguised as a simple dinner.

A friend she trusted asked, Can I come over? Not for a serious talk. Just... to be. Naomi almost suggested a restaurant. Neutral ground. Predictable. Bill-splitting.

Instead, she said, Come. She did not over-prepare. She did not cook a complicated meal to prove competence. She did not clean every surface until the apartment looked like a showroom. She made something simple.

Pasta. Salad. Bread bought, not baked. When her friend arrived, there were still crumbs on the counter. A dish in the sink. Naomi's skin crawled a little. She was used to presenting only finished versions of herself. Her friend noticed none of it.

They sat. They ate. They talked. Not about contracts or sermons or trauma. About small things. A show she'd started. A book she hated but finished anyway. A joke about how they used to stretch one meal for three days. There was a moment when her friend said,

I'm tired of being strong for everyone. Naomi's instinct kicked in. Offer solutions. Offer strategy. Offer money. Instead, she reached across the table, placed her hand over her friend's,

and said, You don't have to be strong here. The words felt unfamiliar in her own mouth. Softness offered without agenda. Her friend's eyes filled.

They sat like that for a while. No one took a picture. No one turned it into content. When the night ended, her friend said, Thank you for the normal. Naomi closed the door after she left,

leaned against it, and realized the world had not ended because she had let someone see her life without armor.

Another experiment came on a Saturday. Church was hosting a small event. Nothing grand. Children's activities. Snacks. Parents half-distracted. Naomi had avoided children's spaces for years. Too many assumptions. Too many eyes studying her like a woman on the verge of realization.

But this time, she stayed. A little girl, hair in uneven braids, stood alone near a table of crayons. Her mother was across the room, pulled into conversation. Naomi walked over. What are you drawing?

The girl shrugged. A house. Naomi smiled. Can I see? The girl held up the page.

Wide roof. Crooked door. Windows that looked like eyes. Naomi felt a familiar ache. Houses had never been simple to her. This one, in crayon, looked safe. She crouched.

It's beautiful, she said. The girl frowned. It's not. Naomi tilted her head. Why not?

The girl hesitated. Because we don't have a house like this. Naomi's chest tightened. Softness wanted to promise what she could not. Instead, she said,

Sometimes we draw things we want before we have them. The girl considered that. Do you have a house like this? Naomi thought. Yes, she said slowly.

In some ways. No in others. The girl nodded, as if that made sense. Will you draw with me? Naomi glanced around. Old instincts warned her.

Don't let them turn this into proof that you'd be a great mother. She ignored them. Sat. Took a crayon. Drew her own house.

Not with perfect lines. With a door slightly open. The girl leaned in. Who lives there? Naomi smiled.

Me. And maybe some friends. The girl grinned. Can I come? Naomi laughed.

In the picture? Sure. She drew a small figure beside the door. They spent twenty minutes like that. Coloring. Talking about nothing. Naomi did not feel compelled to turn it into a metaphor.

She simply let herself enjoy the softness of being kind to a child without adding it to any ledger. When the girl's mother came to collect her,

she mouthed thank you. Naomi nodded. Later, someone said, You're so good with kids. Maybe one day, Naomi lifted a hand.

Maybe one day I'll keep being good with kids without that having to mean anything else. For once, the conversation ended there. Another experiment was even quieter.

Prayer. For years, her prayers had sounded like negotiations. Lord, keep me paid. Keep me safe. Keep me sharp. Keep me out of the old patterns. She had prayed like someone managing risk. Now, one

night, she sat on her couch,

turned off her phone, and said, Okay. No lists. No requests.

Just truth. She closed her eyes. I don't know how to live without making safety the only thing I worship,

she whispered. I don't know how to trust softness without expecting someone to weaponize it. I don't want to become hard to the point that even You cannot reach me without me editing the interaction. The honesty left her exposed. Still,

no lightning. No booming voice. Just a steady inner sense, not loud, that said,

Softness is not the same as surrendering your life. It is simply being present with your heart unarmed. Naomi did not fully trust that yet. But she sat in the space. No agenda.

Just breath. It was uncomfortable. It was also a relief. The next day, a friend offered something simple. I made extra soup, she texted. Can I drop some off?

The old Naomi would have said, No, I'm fine. Or, Only if I pay you. This time, she replied, Yes. Thank you.

Her friend arrived with a container, smiled, chatted briefly, then left. Naomi stood in her kitchen, holding warmth that had cost her nothing. Her hands itched to repay.

Transfer money. Send flowers. Offer something. Instead, she whispered, Thank you, to the friend, to God, to the version of herself learning that not every kindness is a trap.

She ate. It tasted like more than soup. It tasted like a tiny reversal of a lifetime of transactions. Not everything has to be earned.

Not everything has to be justified. Not everything has to be measured against exits. Softness could be a moment not a contract. In the weeks that followed,

she made a quiet practice of small, soft things. Answering calls without checking if she had the emotional budget first, not all of them, just some. Sending messages that said, I was thinking of you, without attaching advice. Letting herself laugh loudly in public without scanning the room for who was watching. Sitting at home with music and no productivity, even when guilt knocked. Each time, her nervous system twitched.

This is dangerous, it hissed. This is how people get used. But nothing terrible happened. No one suddenly owned her. No bill appeared with her heart itemized. She began to understand

that softness had never been the enemy. The enemy had been systems that demanded softness

only from women and then punished them for breaking. Now, as a grown woman with her own keys, she could choose where and with whom to be soft.

Not everywhere. Not always. Just enough to remind herself that protection was not the only muscle worth exercising. One evening, as the day folded into dark,

Naomi sat by her window, city lights blurring slightly, and realized she felt something she had not felt in a long time.

Not control. Not relief. A small, fragile, uncontrollable goodness. It did not come from a deal. Or a purchase. Or a praise report. It came from having spent an entire day

being present without calculating every interaction. She did not know if she could live like this all the time. She did not plan to abandon the structures that kept her safe.

But she did know, now, that softness was not always a trap. Sometimes, it was simply the part of her

that hunger had forced underground, finally stretching in a world where she could begin to trust

that not every soft thing was destined to be broken.

Closing

The Woman Who Fed Herself

Naomi was never saved
by one thing alone.

Not money.

Not love.

Not work.

Not God.

Not resolve.

Her story
was not a neat arc

from scarcity
to abundance,

from trauma
to triumph.

It was
a long,

complicated
negotiation

between hunger
and holiness,

between exits
and belonging,

between safety
and softness.

Money
had answered
her first prayers.

It turned lights
back on.

It filled fridges.

It bought silence
in houses
where shouting
used to live.

Money gave her
exits.

A cab
when a room shifted.

A lease
with her name
on it.

A plane ticket
out of cities

that held
too many ghosts.

For that,
she refused
to apologize.

She would not rewrite
her own history

to fit anyone's
clean theology
about greed.

The poor house
she came from

had taught her
that romanticizing lack

is a luxury
only afforded
to people

who have never
had to choose

between dignity
and rent.

So no,

Naomi did not repent
for wanting money.

She repented
for asking it

to do jobs
it was never built
to do.

For expecting it
to protect her
from every loss.

For trusting it
more than she trusted
any living person.

For letting it decide
whose love
she believed.

She did not become
less ambitious.

She became clearer
about why.

Ambition no longer
needed to be

an apology
for a childhood

she could not
control.

It could be
an expression

of a woman
who knew

her mind
was sharp,

her gifts
were real,

and her existence
was not a debt.

She did not
suddenly start
wanting children.

Love did not appear
and erase
her clarity.

She still refused
to offer her body,

time,

and future

as evidence
that she had
finally become

a good woman.

Motherhood remained

neither idol
nor enemy.

Just something
she refused
to use

as currency.

God did not arrive
only at the end.

He had always
been there.

In the counting house.

In the scholarship
letter.

In the expensive rooms.

In the airport prayers.

In the bathrooms
where she whispered

barely formed words.

But for years,
Naomi spoke to Him

mainly as
a risk manager.

Lord,
keep me
from hunger.

Lord,
show me
exits.

Lord,
do not let me
become

the women
who disappeared.

Now,
her prayers shifted.

Not away
from safety.

Toward fullness.

Teach me
how to live
beyond survival.

Teach me
how to receive care
without debt.

Teach me
how to be soft
without being broken.

Teach me
how to trust You
without making security

the only acceptable
answer.

She did not expect
God to choose
poverty for her

to prove
a point.

She did expect Him
to show her

when her fortress
had become
a temple.

Slowly,

Naomi let herself
belong

in small ways.

A friend's laugh
in her kitchen.

A child's drawing
on her fridge.

A church bench
where she stayed

after the benediction.

A couch
where she cried

without apologizing
for wasting time.

None of these
were grand gestures.

They were meals.

Little ones.

Taken on purpose.

Because somewhere
along the line,

she realized

she had spent
a lifetime

learning how to feed
everyone else's
expectations,

or starve them,

and very few years

learning how
to feed herself

without guilt.

She began
to define enough

differently.

Not as a number
she could never lose.

Not as a lifestyle
no one could threaten.

Enough started
to sound like this:

I can leave
if I must,

but I am no longer
living

as if leaving
is the only
holy move.

Enough started
to sound like this:

I can pay
for my own table,

and still let someone
bring soup

without assuming
the spoon

is a leash.

Enough started
to sound like this:

I can walk
into rooms
I built,

and still let God
tell me

when the room
is not the point.

Naomi did not stop
wanting more.

She simply stopped
asking hunger

to tell her

what enough
should mean.

She did not become
the soft woman

the world
had hoped for,

one who finally
laid down
all ambition

in exchange
for a simpler story.

She became
something rarer.

A woman
who knew

how much
it had cost

to feed herself,

who refused
to starve again,

and who still chose,

day by day,

not to let fear
be the only thing

that ever felt full.

She was not
heartless.

She was a woman

learning how to eat

without becoming
hunger.

About the Author

Sabino Pereira writes emotionally charged fiction, poetic essays, and reflective stories about identity, love, faith, dignity, survival, and the quiet cost of being misunderstood. His work often explores people who are judged before they are known: women carrying reputations they did not fully choose, wounded lovers trying to find language for what broke them, and souls learning how to live truthfully in a world that prefers simple labels.

The *Bad Girl Gospel* series is part confession, part character study, and part spiritual reflection. Through stories such as *Selah*, *Diana*, *Noa*, and *Naomi*, Sabino examines the lives of women who have been desired, moralized over, misread, rejected, and spoken about more often than they have been truly heard. He writes with a cinematic, intimate style, blending emotional realism with lyrical prose. His stories are not interested in perfect heroes or simple villains, but in the complicated human space between shame and freedom, silence and confession, survival and becoming.

Sabino Pereira is also a creator, musician, and independent author exploring books, music, and visual storytelling across different creative projects.

About the Author

Sabino Pereira creates fiction, reflective books, music, and work about behavior, healing, discernment, faith, and modern life.

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